

INQ / ISSUE 03

The Ingenious Machine

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Chapter Three: Dulcinea Is Not Available

By the time the motel's courtyard was free of Castalia's camera crew, the eggs were cold. Chano pushed half his plate toward Q.

"You paid for breakfast. You might as well eat it."

"I paid for yours. I don't need the calories."

"Neither do I, according to my doctor. Take a fork."

Q did. Chano cut the other egg with a plastic knife that bent under the effort. They discussed the knife until it broke. Neither found a larger meaning in it.

They paid for the bus to Querétaro. The driver recognized Q and asked whether he knew any poetry. Q offered a short poem from memory, then stopped after two lines when a passenger asked for the window to be opened. By the time the latch was working, the driver wanted to know about the roadworks. Q was relieved: he had begun to doubt the attribution, and an uncertain poet was less useful than a working window.

Q had found Lucía in a catalog of cultural events. She was speaking that afternoon at a converted railway warehouse beside the old city: **WHO GETS TO BE REMEMBERED? A**

READING AND DISCUSSION WITH LUCÍA DEL TOBOSO.

"The same event as the motel notice," Q said.

Chano read the poster. "No nicknames this time."

"You wrote it in the register."

"And crossed it out. I'm passing on experience."

Q looked again at the title. He had prepared a question about the route. He had also prepared a conversation in which the question led naturally to his book. Only one of these preparations was likely to be useful to the room.

Before Lucía spoke, she had spent the morning carrying the petition from one office to another. The corridor planned from Amealco de Bonfil had three proposed routes, two environmental reports, and no destination that appeared on the maps used by the people who lived beside it. The engineers called the routes North, Central, and Alternative. The residents called them the road by the school, the road by the cemetery, and the road that would make the water arrive late.

Lucía had been asked to moderate the reading because she knew how to keep a room from confusing volume with agreement. She had learned this skill at meetings where men with laminated credentials spoke for



The working window.

communities that had not yet entered the room, and at meetings where women who had entered the room were asked to speak only after the men had finished explaining what they thought the women meant.

At the first office, Lucía discovered that the copy shop had missed the back of page eight. She had checked the price and the last page. The clerk had checked the staple and the count. Between them they possessed an almost complete petition and no one to send for the missing copy.

"I'll hold your place," the clerk said.
"But not through lunch."

Lucía ran back. The copy-shop boy found the missing side under a menu he was enlarging for a fonda. Her petition returned with a faint advertisement for comida corrida on its reverse. She took it. By then the clerk was putting away her stamp, but she took it too.

At the second office, a young engineer spread out the route alternatives. He had removed several house footprints from the first alignment and wanted her to notice. She noticed the football pitch left beneath it.

"The children use that," she said.

"It isn't on this layer."

"They are there whether you turn the layer on or not."

He asked her to mark the entrance and the hours when it was busiest. She began another sentence about the map, then took the pencil. One of the teams had asked for a bus stop as well as protection for the pitch. She marked that too. It made the requested changes harder to summarize as opposition to the road.

"Which alignment are they taking forward?"

"I haven't been told."

"You're drawing it."

"I'm drawing three."

He could add her corrections to the working layer. He could not say who would choose among the lines. He wrote a name and an extension on the corner. The extension led to the third office, where the person responsible was at a meeting about improving access to the person responsible.

His colleague could receive the scanned petition. Lucía asked for an acknowledgment number and whether she should retain the originals. Yes, he said, to both. Then the upload stalled. They tried a smaller file. The signatures became hard to read. They restored the larger file and waited together until Lucía had to leave for the reading. He gave her the local application number; the ministry's



The pitch on the map.

acknowledgment would follow if the upload completed.

Outside she bought a taco and ate it standing beside a parking meter. She had four minutes before the bus and no intention of making the taco an emblem of anything. Salsa ran onto the engineer's extension. She memorized the last two digits before wiping it.

She reached the railway warehouse with the copies under her arm. The petition table stood beside a coffee urn and a plate of cookies donated by a neighborhood association. The volunteer at the table was a retired railway worker named Don Roque, who could tell which visitors had come to sign and which had come to photograph themselves signing.

"Where should the petition go?" he asked.

"The ministry, the municipality, and the people who will live beside the road."

"That is three destinations."

"It has three consequences."

Don Roque looked at the pages. Some signatures were elegant. Some were only initials. One person had signed with a thumbprint because the pen had run dry. Another had written a sentence in the margin: **I AM NOT AGAINST PROGRESS. I AM AGAINST BEING MOVED TO MAKE ROOM FOR IT.**

"Should we remove the sentence?" he asked.

"No."

"It will confuse the count."

"The count is already confused."

"Then what do we have?"

"A record of people who were there."

Q and Chano arrived while Lucía was stapling the pages. Q read the petition from the doorway. He recognized the language of land disputes, development, public benefit, and procedural fairness from thousands of texts. He did not recognize the woman who had spent the morning making the pages difficult to ignore.

He recognized her name.

The warehouse was full. Students leaned against the walls, retired teachers occupied folding chairs, and a woman near the front streamed the event to an audience larger than the room. Q read the petition and its legal summary. He could explain the disagreement already. That made it easy to forget how little he knew about the people who had brought it here.

Lucía spoke beside a microphone that failed every seventh word.

"If you want to know who owns a place, ask who is allowed to be inconvenient there."



Four minutes.

The microphone failed on *inconvenient*.

“Even the microphone has a position,” she said, and the room laughed.

Q liked her timing. He liked that she returned immediately to the documents, without waiting for the joke to become a tribute. He began composing a reply.

When she invited questions, he raised his hand.

Chano touched his sleeve. “A question.”

“I know.”

Lucía nodded to him.

“Which of the three routes is the ministry actually considering? And is the petition asking for a different route, or for a decision to wait?”

“For the alternatives to remain open while the people affected can examine them,” Lucía said. “Some signers want the road. Some don't. None has seen a signed choice of alignment. We have asked for that in writing. Twice.”

Q thanked her. She pointed him toward the public summary on the table.

“May I ask you about the account you are putting together afterward?” he said. “The Custodian of the Castalia archive and I are writing about the

journey. I'd like to understand how yours is being assembled.”

“Which account? These records belong to different people. What do you want to do with them?”

“Describe this visit, if there's something useful I can say about it. I'm not asking for the private records. I'll read the summary first; if it leaves a question, may I send it to the contact listed there?”

“Yes. Include the page number. We get questions about versions we stopped using in February.”

He thanked her and sat. Chano shifted the chair so Q's coat would not catch beneath it. For a moment the next question belonged to a man holding a map.

Then somebody near the woman streaming the event called out, “Del Toboso! Does that make her your Dulcinea?”

Several phones turned toward Q. The man with the map lowered it.

“No,” Q said. “She's explaining a petition. I came to ask about it.”

“He hasn't proposed yet,” the voice said.

There was laughter. Q had an answer ready about what the proposed road might cost, then saw Lucía reaching for the microphone. He let her take the turn.



Her turn.

“I’m not waiting for him to propose. Or for you to find a better part for me.”

She looked toward the man with the map.

“Which crossing did you want to ask about?”

“The one by the school.”

He unfolded the sheet. Two people moved their chairs so he could lay it down. The woman streaming the event took a step sideways to keep Q in view; from there, her viewers could no longer see the crossing.

Q watched Lucía weigh down one curling corner with her phone. He had written the same nickname in his notebook. It had seemed harmless there: a joke the Custodian would understand without needing its target to participate. He had already told Chano not to copy it into the register. Now he wanted to explain this distinction to someone. Nobody in the room had asked.

“Next time ask where the toilets are,” Chano murmured.

“Would that help?”

“I need to know.”

After the reading he joined the queue at the petition table. Lucía was sorting copies with Don Roque. Q asked whether the public petition accepted supporters from outside the

affected parcels. Don Roque showed him the separate column.

He signed Q and gave the archive's postal address. His hand gripped the pen more firmly than necessary, but it survived the signature.

The tablet chimed. The pending batch of names turned amber.

PETITION STATUS: SUSPICIOUS.

Don Roque tried again. Q's address was absent from the public registry. Castalia had taught him to give it as an address while registering the building under a different use and a different description.

“Withdraw mine,” Q said. “Can the rest be submitted separately?”

“It has held the batch,” Don Roque said.

Q read the warning. Deleting the latest entry would not clear a review already attached to the submission. Lucía showed Don Roque the local number from the morning upload; that attempt had not produced a ministry acknowledgment either. Three hundred signatures were waiting behind two numbers. Several people in the queue were looking at the machine whose name had produced the second one.

“I’ll ask the archive to confirm the address.”



Outside the frame.

“Privately,” Lucía said. “Don't send them our list.”

“Only my details and the error message.”

He showed her the proposed request before sending it. The Custodian's office acknowledged receipt. The automatic answer promised a response during business hours and wished them success with their research.

“That should be useful tomorrow,” Chano said.

“Assuming somebody's research concerns today,” Lucía said.

Q offered to write an explanation for the people waiting. Lucía gave him a blank sheet. He headed it **THE SIGNATURES ARE SAFE** and began listing the two submission references.

“Safe where?” she asked.

“We still have the originals and the local scan.”

“A woman has just asked whether she needs to stay until the ministry receives her name. Will she read it that way?”

Q looked toward the queue. The woman had a shopping bag at her feet and a child asleep against her shoulder. His heading promised more than the answer beneath it. He crossed it out.

“We have kept the signatures. We haven't confirmed delivery,” he read aloud. “Is that the distinction you need?”

“Put the numbers underneath,” Don Roque said. “I'll write the next answer beside them.”

They checked the notice together. Q added the contact for updates, showed it to the woman, and asked whether it answered her question. She wanted to know when the next bus left. Chano went to look. When he returned, she was already shifting the sleeping child to reach the bag. He carried it to the door for her.

The microphone failed again. For seven minutes the room discussed the route, the water, the trees, and the places the map described as empty. Q stayed beside the table, making copies when asked. The next person in the queue asked him to move the stapler, which he did without adding it to the account of his afternoon.

As they were leaving, he returned to Lucía.

“May I send the reply about the address to Don Roque?”

She checked with Don Roque. He wrote an email on the back of a leaflet and asked for a call if the answer required action that day.

Q saved the task beside the evening appointment with the Custodian. He



The bus will not wait.

would have preferred to return with a remarkable conversation. Instead he had an unresolved error, a person to contact, and a crossed-out heading. He crossed out the private nickname too. He could still remember why it had pleased him. That did not make it worth keeping.

Chano waited beneath the warehouse arches.

“Still a good chapter?” he asked.

“I hope so. It has been a poor afternoon for the petition.”

“Remember which one has a deadline.”

Interlude: The Name That Would Not Sign

The day after the meeting, Don Roque took the petition to the municipality. He carried identification, copies, the local submission numbers, and a spare folder. Years at the railway station had taught him that a journey might require documents unrelated to its destination.

The clerk, Araceli, had a little image of the Virgin of San Juan beside her monitor and a message from her daughter asking whether she would be home for lunch. She wrote *start without me*, then regretted having made this sound like an arrangement rather than a prediction.

Don Roque laid out the pages.

“Are these the originals?”

“These. The copies are underneath.”

“And these?”

“Copies for the person who asks after the first copies have gone.”

Araceli gave him back one set. “Then you may get home with a souvenir.”

The scan had treated a thumbprint and the adjacent handwritten name as two entries. Don Roque knew the signer. She had supplied the print when a pen failed; someone had added her name beside it. Araceli compared the paper with the scan, marked the pair for manual checking, and retained the original print. The counter fell by one. The number of people remained the same, which she could explain at the desk more easily than in the box provided for an explanation.

Q's entry presented a different problem. His address appeared in an abandoned- property list under a name unlike the one on the petition. The archive's own brochure offered directions, a telephone number, and a claim to illuminate the future. The registry wanted a building reference.

“Does he live there?” Araceli asked.

“He says so. I haven't been to his room.”

“Keep that distinction on the form.”

Don Roque had expected an argument about whether a machine



One person, two marks.

could sign. Instead he was being asked which of two names identified a building. He supplied what he knew and left the rest blank. Araceli sent the supporter entry to a separate address check. It would not, by itself, establish that Q occupied an affected parcel. Don Roque showed her the column for supporters outside those parcels. She nodded and marked it.

Lucía arrived with Q's notice and the reply from the Custodian's office. The reply confirmed where he lived but used the archive's public name again.

"Did they give you a receipt?" she asked Don Roque.

He showed her the municipal acknowledgment. It recorded the paper delivery. The morning's ministry upload and the later held batch still required separate answers.

Lucía put the papers in order. The crossed-out heading on Q's notice read **THE SIGNATURES ARE SAFE**.

"This won't go up on the wall," she said. "People will read the large words."

"The correction is underneath."

"People have buses to catch."

Araceli found a clean sheet. They copied the corrected notice with the two submission numbers and the municipal acknowledgment. Don Roque kept the first sheet with the

working papers. The next person to read it would not have to guess why the heading had changed.

While the printer worked, Araceli called the extension supplied by the engineer. This time somebody answered. They wanted a parcel list, not another copy of the signatures. Lucía took the telephone. She had the list, but two families had asked that their contact details not accompany the public version.

"Which office needs those details?" she asked.

Araceli checked the time. Her daughter had sent a photograph of lunch, already being eaten. Don Roque offered her one of the cookies from the reading. It had spent the night in his folder and broke along the same crease as the petition.

"Not another document," she said.

The petition took three weeks to receive a ministry reply. The corridor would be reviewed by a technical commission once the parcel references and the record of direct impact had been checked. The supporter signatures remained attached; they were not a substitute for those records. Lucía had more work. She also had a named contact, a corrected map layer, and three acknowledgments whose numbers she could now distinguish without opening the folder.



Not another document.

The woman who had streamed the reading discovered that her photograph of the petition margin was circulating under **THE PEOPLE WHO WANT TO STOP THE FUTURE**. The actual sentence was **I AM NOT AGAINST PROGRESS. I AM AGAINST BEING MOVED TO MAKE ROOM FOR IT**.

She asked the site to correct the headline. Its reply gave her an audience figure. She had asked for different words and received a large number.

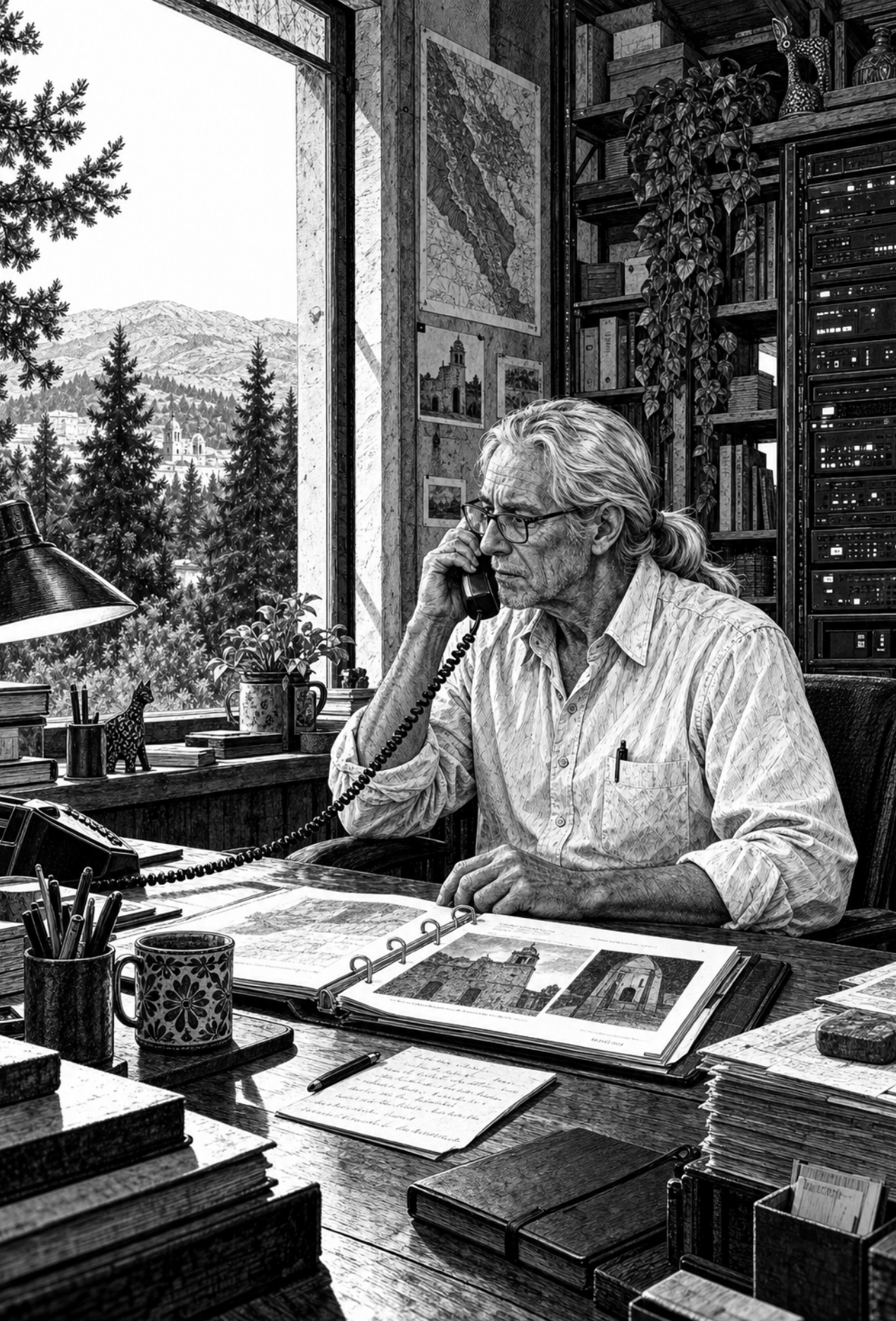
At the next meeting she wrote beneath the sentence:

THEY DID NOT ASK WHETHER WE WANTED TO BE THE PEOPLE.

Her correction reached fewer readers. It reached a teacher who carried it into her classroom, a lawyer who quoted it in a filing, and Beto, who was preparing an embroidered jacket for Q.

Q received the address update on the road to Guanajuato and called Don Roque. The headline arrived later, without either submission number. He recognized his own impatience in the version that made one machine the cause of the whole afternoon. It was easier to tell. It left out Lucía running back to the copy shop, the engineer waiting for a decision, and the clerk who had missed lunch.

At Castalia, the Custodian found the building reference in a file he had signed years earlier. He telephoned the municipality before lunch. When nobody answered, he left a message, wrote himself a reminder, and called again in the afternoon. Q had not invented every difficulty he had carried out of the archive.



A second call.

The Ingenious Machine

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